wishers who perceive India's rise as being in their strategic interest. Harnessing the calculations of others is clearly a useful tactic but one to be practised with both prudence and self-confidence. The obverse is no less important, and standing up to intimidation and pressures is part of our maturing. Not least, there has to be a reasonable expectation that a rising power will be tested. The quality of leadership and the ability to perform better on the ground is certainly helping to set India apart.

That India matters and will matter more with the passage of time can be convincingly asserted. Like so many other developments in politics and history, it must never be taken as preordained. There will always be doubters among us who cannot believe that our nation can even dare to think big. There are vested interests, too, that will masquerade as political correctness and global consensus. We have seen for too long attempts to distance us from our history, traditions and culture. At the end of the day, much will ride on our national unity and collective purpose. Being a serious global player requires ambition and strategy to be backed by initiative, perseverance and energy. Our own people and leadership must embrace their destiny to realize their aspirations. Keeping the faith and getting down to work are good ways to demonstrate it.

Why India matters should also be approached from the perspective of to whom it matters. As a larger factor in international affairs, it clearly features more prominently in the calculations of the rest of the world. At a time of global transition, this is particularly relevant to the larger states that are seeking to shape that process. Obviously, a rising India would also matter more to its competitors. Those who took India's limitations and shortcomings as a given will surely now reassess its progress and prospects. For India's neighbours, the benefits and comfort of being proximate to a generous and non-reciprocal polity are becoming increasingly apparent. For the rest of the Global South, a more powerful India is, if anything, even better.

Overall, the international community today engages India with greater enthusiasm and expectations. That is something that Indians should assess by themselves and from which they must draw conclusions. There will always be the polemicists and critics, but even for them, an India that will not bend to ideological bullying and be deflected from its course is one that they will have to take more seriously.